

ECONOMICS OF CRIME (ECON 120)

Spring 2026

Instructor:	Marisa Cameron	Time:	TR 1:15 - 2:35
Email:	marisa.cameron@pomona.edu	Place:	CA 109

How to contact me:

Email: marisa.cameron@pomona.edu

Office hours: Wednesday from 3:00-4:00 and Thursday from 3:00-4:00 in Carnegie 204 and by appointment through Calendly:

<https://calendly.com/mcot2024-pomona/15min>

Note: Monday is my research day, in which I do not have any meetings. I will do my best to respond promptly to emails, but I like to have a balanced life. Please trust that I will get back to you as soon as possible, usually within 24 hours on weekdays.

Introduction

Welcome! This course provides an introduction to the study of crime and crime-control policies using standard economic techniques. Criminal behavior is considered the result of rational decisions made by individuals seeking to maximize their well-being within the constraints of society. The focus is on incentives for individuals to commit crimes and how those incentives can be changed by public policy. Topics include the costs of crime to society, drug control, gun control, non-violent and violent crime, gang-related crimes, punishment, incarceration, and deterrence.

Sensitive Material: We cover a variety of sensitive topics throughout the course of the semester, and there are topics you may wish to avoid. Some potentially sensitive topics include rape, overdose, capital punishment, terrorism, and gun violence. A course outline is posted below so you can see what material is covered each week. If you know there are topics that will impact your mental health, please alert me as soon as you feel comfortable

Learning goals:

- Explore real-world applications of microeconomic concepts.
- Improve reading and comprehension of professional vocabulary.
- Develop foundational data visualization skills.
- Enhance creativity skills

Attendance Policy: Given the structure of our course, you don't need to inform me when you miss class. Our Canvas weekly announcement can help you keep up with what's going on. Most assignments are completed online, but a portion of your grade is based on small quizzes we do in class each day. The grading policy has already been designed to be flexible in a way that allows you to miss these poll questions occasionally during the semester and still earn credit.

Tableau TA: We are fortunate to have Izzy Sabatino as our Tableau teaching assistant. The Tableau TA office hours are dedicated to helping you work with Tableau. Izzy's Tableau office hours are 8:00 - 9:30 PM on Mondays and 10:00 - 11:30 AM on Wednesdays, location TBD.

Course Materials:

Lectures are based on my notes from the recommended textbook, discussion of articles posted to Canvas, readings from required books, and videos shown in class. Used copies of the books sell online for much less

and cover the same material.

Required Materials:

- **Narconomics: How to Run a Drug Cartel** by Tom Wainright, *ISBN-13: 978-1610397704*
- **American Prison: A Reporter's Undercover Journey into the Business of Punishment** by Shane Bauer, *ISBN-13: 978-0735223585*
- **Tableau Desktop Account** available at link here *Note:* Registration information is posted on Canvas
- **iClicker Cloud** available on mobile devices or web browser. *Note:* Registration information is posted on Canvas

Recommended Materials:

- **Wireless mouse** *Note:* This will make working with Tableau much easier.
- **The Economics of Crime: An Introduction to Rational Crime Analysis** by Harold Winter *ISBN-13: 978-0415771740* *Note:* This is the book that my notes will be largely based on.

Assessments

There are no exams in the course, but rather a collection of projects based on course material, published literature reports connected to course content, and weekly quizzes based on assigned reading for each week. There is some room for you to drop items in which you perform poorly or miss unexpectedly.

Course Component	Overall Weight
Tableau Assignments	
Guided Projects (Best 4 of 5)	40%
Independent Project	10%
Final Portfolio	10%
Engagement Activities	
Weekly Quizzes (Best 12)	18%
Clicker Polling	10%
Referee Report (Best 3 of 4)	9%
Tableau Certification	3%
Total Graded Material	100%

Weekly Quizzes

Each week has assigned readings from either course books (American Prison and Narconomics) or from additional readings posted on Canvas. The entire reading list is posted on Canvas, and all readings should be completed by the end of the week. In class on Tuesday, you'll have 10 minutes to take the quiz (bluebooks will be provided). The quiz will be randomly selected in class, and you will be quizzed over either the readings from the previous week or one of the lectures from the previous week lectures. Your poll questions each week are taken from the weekly readings as well. You should prepare your responses to the quiz questions before class on Tuesday so you can reference your notes while taking the quiz.

Failure to turn in your quiz answer in class on Tuesday (regardless of the reason) will result in a zero for the quiz. The questions you will be asked are based on the following guidelines:

Previous Material:

After each class, spend 5–10 minutes summarizing that day's lecture material. If a lecture quiz is selected,

you will need to adequately summarize a day from the previous week. Do not copy the material from the slides or else you will not receive credit for summarizing the material. These summaries will also be helpful for your projects as well.

Reading Material:

You will be asked to provide one of the following responses to one of the required readings from the previous week. You will be asked to do one of the following for one of the readings:

1. *Summary*: Describe the major thesis, the central idea or set of ideas, in the reading.
2. *Application*: Select a concept or principle in the reading, clearly define or describe it, and then indicate how it applies to you or someone you know. Provide sufficient details to justify convincingly that the concept or principle applies as you suggest.

Referee Reports

You will complete four referee reports throughout the semester; your top three will count towards your final grade. For each referee report there will be an assigned research paper you will be expected to read. The referee reports will consist of a general synopsis of the paper, data used, methodology, significant findings, any portions of the paper you found particularly interesting or worth noting, and any revisions you would recommend. A rubric and assignment sample is available on Canvas.

Projects

There are five guided projects to complete during the course of the semester. Your best four project scores count toward your final grade in the course, but all projects must be completed for your final portfolio. Projects require you to create 3-4 data visualizations and arrange those visualizations onto a dashboard using Tableau. These dashboards will be posted publicly and are graded based on the quality of your presentation, not on completion. Your project grade related to the dashboard is marked by peer reviews you receive from classmates. A small portion of each project score comes from completing peer reviews of your classmates' dashboards.

Your project grades also includes a 3-page paper summarizing the dashboard you created, summarizing additional reading material, and connecting your dashboard back to class material. You are required to cite sources and provide a reference page as well. There is a 3-page maximum on the length of your paper, so clear and concise writing is important.

The final project in the course is completed on your own. You will collect your own data, determine appropriate visualizations, and organize your dashboard around a topic of your choosing. The grading process is similar for the final project and requires peer reviews of your classmates and a 3-page paper.

Assignment	Due Date
Project #1	February 5
Project #2	February 19
Project #3	March 5
Project #4	March 26
Project #5	April 9
Independent Project	April 30

Portfolio

The final assignment in the course is a portfolio of the work you've completed this semester. You will take all six projects from the semester and create a webpage displaying your work. Your grade on the portfolio is based on updating the projects from earlier in the semester based on the feedback you received from your peer reviews. The final portfolio is due at the end of our assigned final exam block, and the overall grade is

based on the website and two surveys.

iClicker Polls

We will use iClicker Cloud during class to assess your progress throughout the semester. Poll questions are graded such that you'll receive 1 point for participating in the question and 1 additional point for answering the question correctly (when applicable). The course is divided into two halves and graded based on the points available in each half. The following table details what fraction of the total available poll points you need in order to earn the corresponding grade on the Canvas assignment:

Fraction of Poll Points Earned	Canvas Score Earned
0-49.99%	No credit
50%-59.99%	25%
60%-69.99%	50%
70%-74.99%	75%
75%-100%	100%

You must participate with the iClicker student app on a smartphone/tablet or use the web version on your laptop **with geolocation enabled**.

iClicker activities fall under the provisions of Pomona College's Honor Code. Students must not engage in academic dishonesty while participating in iClicker activities. This includes but is not limited to:

- Answering polling questions while not physically in the classroom
- Looking at other students' devices when instructed not to
- Submitting answers for more than one iClicker account at a time

Any student found to be in violation of these rules risks losing all their iClicker points for the entire term.

Tableau Desktop Certification

Tableau offers professional certifications through Trailhead Academy. In this course, you will have the opportunity to earn the Salesforce Certified Tableau Desktop Foundations certification by the end of the semester. This certification is intended for individuals who have foundational knowledge of Tableau Desktop and at least three months of experience applying these skills within the software.

Through support from the Hahn Teaching with Technology Grant, Pomona College is subsidizing the cost of the certification exam. You are allowed to retake the certification test for free. You will submit your exam results on Canvas after taking the certification test. If you take the certification exam and do not pass, you will still earn 1.5% towards your overall grade; you will earn the full 3% if you take the test and pass it. If you do not attempt the certification test at all, you will not earn any points.

Grading Distribution: The grade minimums below are firm percentage values to earn the corresponding grade. Final scores will not be rounded to a higher grade at the end of the semester. Any final score less than 60% will result in an F for the course regardless of the amount of work completed during the term.

Grade Scale	
Minimum Score	Grade Earned
94.00%	A
90.00%	A-
87.50%	B+
82.50%	B
80.00%	B-
77.50%	C+
72.50%	C
70.00%	C-
67.50%	D+
62.50%	D
60.00%	D-
< 60.00%	F

Missing Assignments & Late Work Policy

Most assignments in the course (Tableau, Weekly Quizzes, and Referee Reports) are available over multiple days so that you can work ahead of the deadline. As such, there are no makeup assignments available and no late work is accepted for these assignments. If you have any questions about how a missed assignment impacts your final grade, come by during office hours.

There may be times where you miss a deadline or are not able to submit an assignment before the deadline. Each category (including Guided Projects) allows for some assignment scores to be dropped at the end of the semester so that missing an assignment or day of class doesn't negatively impact your final grade. If you miss an assignment, for whatever reason, it can still be eligible to be dropped at the end of the term. You should complete your work as early as possible to avoid any unforeseen circumstances that prevent you from submitting them at the deadline (illness, computer issues, job interviews, etc).

Grade Revision

If you believe that an assignment was graded incorrectly or if you are missing a grade for an assignment you earned, you have 1 week from the time that the grades are posted to notify me about the missing grade during office hours. No grade-revision requests will be considered after this deadline. Keep a close eye on your grades throughout the semester. The grade-revision process is different for each assignment, but I will always personally regrade any work that you ask me to regrade. I will regrade the entire work, not just the contested portion, which means that it is possible that your updated grade will be lower than the grade you were originally assigned. My grade will be the final grade.

AI Policy

Use of ChatGPT or other LLMs in this course is permitted under limited circumstances. All use of generative AI must be properly cited and documented. Students are required to save session logs and attach them to the appendix of submitted work. The most applicable use of AI in this course is code generation. You are required to include "Do not generate code. Only explain the concepts." in the prompt. An author's statement will be required with assignment submissions. An author's statement should include whether or not AI was used. If AI tools were used how you used them should be included.

Students are responsible for identifying and addressing any inaccurate, biased, offensive, or problematic AI-generated content that they use or cite.

Student work that does not include the required elements (citations, author's statement, etc.) shall receive a grade penalty and discuss the submission with the instructor in office hours.

Tentative Course Outline:

Week	Topics
1	Course Introduction
2	Punishments & Fines
3	Prisons
4	The Death Penalty
5	Race & Crime
6	Private Crime Deterrence
7	Drug Policies
8	Social Reforms
9	Organized Crime
10	Terrorism
11	Alcohol
12	Sports
13	Prostitution
14	Financial Crimes
15	Final Presentations

Resources:**Center for Speaking, Writing, and the Image:**

The Center for Speaking, Writing, and the Image (formerly The Writing Center) is open this semester! We open at full capacity after the second week of the semester, but we will be holding limited appointments and drop-in hours as soon as classes begin. Writing and Speaking Partners meet one-on-one with students to talk about their work and provide feedback at any stage of their preparation process. Trained to think deeply about written, oral, and visual rhetoric and communication, these student peers facilitate conversations about everything from ID1 papers to senior theses, lab reports to creative writing, giving presentations to developing strategies for reading and engaging more deeply and confidently in class discussion. Jenny Thomas, Asst. Director of College Writing and Language Diversity, offers specialized writing and speaking support for multilingual students navigating English as an additional language. To make an appointment with a Writing or Speaking Partner, please log onto the Portal and go to Academics, Writing Center or contact us at writing.center@pomona.edu. We offer both in-person and virtual appointments, and we have regular drop-in hours in SCC 148.

Quantitative Skills Center:

The Quantitative Skills Center (QSC) provides academic support to Pomona College students in courses that feature a large degree of quantitative and/or scientific reasoning through our QSC Partners Program. QSC partners meet one-on-one with students to provide support for a variety of Pomona courses for course specific help. The QSC also offers non-course specific help in general quantitative skills and offers consultations for projects and theses involving quantitative methods. Additionally, Dr. Travis Brown, Director of the QSC, and Dr. Dylan Worcester, Assistant Director of the QSC are available to meet with you regarding your success in STEM at Pomona College. To make an appointment at the QSC, please visit pomona.mywconline.com, or contact us at qsc@pomona.edu.

Accommodations:

I am committed to creating a course that is inclusive in its design and structure. Please contact disability-services@pomona.edu to request accommodations. If you encounter any barriers to your learning, please let me know immediately so that we can determine if there is an adjustment that can be made or if an accom-

modation might be needed to overcome the limitations of the course. I am always happy to consider creative solutions as long as they do not compromise the standards of the course, the intent of the assignments, or learning activities.

Mental Health Resources:

Being back to in person meetings is hard. Trauma, living with (diagnosed or undiagnosed) anxiety, depression, eating disorders, thoughts / behaviors of self-harm, or some other mental health concern can make it harder to reach learning potential. I want this to be a better and more humane experience for you. If you ever find yourself struggling, please ask for help from me, your colleagues, or your school. Here are some campus resources: Monsour Counseling and Wellness Phone (909) 621-8202 After hours emergency (909) 607-2000 <https://www.cuc.claremont.edu/mcaps/> Title IX makes it clear that violence and harassment based on sex and gender are Civil Rights offenses subject to the same kinds of accountability and the same kinds of support applied to offenses against other protected categories such as race, national origin, etc. If you or someone you know has been harassed or assaulted, you can find the appropriate resources at <http://7csexualmisconductresources.claremont.edu>.

Covid Safety Awareness

The faculty at Pomona College knows that person-to-person interaction provides the best liberal arts education. The best learning occurs in small communities. Our health, both mental and physical, is paramount. We must consider the health of others inside and outside the classroom. We need to take care of each other for this course to be successful. I ask you therefore to adhere to the following principles:

- Class attendance is highly encouraged, but if you need to miss class for health reasons, concerning symptoms, suspected Covid exposure, unexpected dependent care, technology issues, or other emergency reasons I will work with you. Let me underscore this: please make your decisions always based on health, safety, and wellness—yours and others—and I will work with you at the other end.

Subject to Change Statement:

Information contained in the course syllabus may be subject to change with notice.